

5.2 What students need to learn if choosing composition

1 Overview

Students should be given a wide range of opportunities to further extend their composition skills. Study should include:

- idiomatic writing for the chosen forces (including ICT if appropriate), and the efficient and sensitive handling of timbres and textures
- extending understanding of the principles of rhythmic, melodic and harmonic construction and the working of form(s) and structure(s) appropriate to the composition undertaken.

Students should also study appropriate models drawn from the anthology and elsewhere. Students should continue to practise composing to a given brief and specified time limit.

2 Areas of study

As part of the final submission task, students choose the composition brief(s) from a selection of four set by Edexcel.

Note: Students must complete two tasks in Unit 5, choosing from **either** one composition and one technical study **or** two compositions **or** two technical studies.

When preparing, students and teachers should note the following guidance for the individual topics. Students should be also aware of the assessment criteria that the compositions will be marked against. Subject to the demands of the composition brief, they may write for their own choice of instrumental and/or vocal forces.

Area of study Instrumental music: Topic 1: Development and contrast

Students should investigate processes of musical development including motivic development (eg by inversion or fragmentation), variation techniques and how such processes can be applied to create varied musical structures (eg rondo, sonata form).

Area of study Instrumental music : Topic 2: Exploiting instruments

Students should investigate the concept of writing technically challenging music for acoustic instruments, how this can be exploited sensitively and practically, and how different levels of practical demand and different manners of instrumental writing can be coordinated effectively within a single piece.

Area of study Applied music: Topic 3: Music for film and television

Students should consider how music can be used to take the listener on a complex and musically satisfying emotional journey in parallel with the moving image on film and television (and therefore often independently of traditional music forms and structures). Neither close synchronisation of film and music nor the submission of video or DVD clips is required.

Area of study Applied music: Topic 4: Music, dance and theatre

Students should consider the relationships between music and dance in a variety of social and dramatic contexts, and how music can be used in the theatre (both vocally and instrumentally).